



廣外高級翻譯學院
GDUFS School of Interpreting & Translation Studies

A Study on the Performability of the English Translation of *1699 Peach Blossom Fan*

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Research Background

Drama is not only a literary art but also a performing art (孟伟根, 2012: 7). It is only through performance that the dramatic art can be presented in full (Ubersfeld, 1996: 15-16). Therefore, for drama translation, especially the translation used for stage performance, performability should be taken into consideration.

Research Questions

1. Whether the English subtitles for *1699 Peach Blossom Fan* achieve performability?
2. What translation methods contribute to achieving the readability, intelligibility, actability and individuality of actors' lines in *1699 Peach Blossom Fan*?

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Research Significance

Theoretical significance:

- Combining the framework of performability research with subtitle translation research and replacing the research dimension of speakability with the “readability” of subtitles
- Adding more operational indexes to explore the performability

Practical significance:

- Providing drama translators with a reference on methods of translating the subtitles for Chinese opera performances, especially those of Kunqu Opera
- Providing a research idea or direction for scholars who intend to explore the performability of the translations of other Chinese dramas in the future.

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- **Previous Studies on Performability**

Proposal:

Susan Bassnett (1980) first proposes that drama translators should follow the standard of performability. She believes that a dramatic text should have distinct features that can be performed such as subtext or action text, and the translator must find out such features and then translate them into the target language that is acceptable (Bassnett, 1980).

Speakability:

Fluent, smooth and natural translation (Landers, 2001; Espasa, 2000; Hamberg, 1969; 朱生豪, 1958)

No difficulty in pronunciation (Wellwarth, 1981)

Oral and concise translation (李昌盛等, 2014; 余光中, 2002; 英若誠, 1999)

Rhythm of the translation (魏城璧、李忠庆, 2012; Hornby, 1997)

- **Previous Studies on Performability**

Acceptability:

Translation should be based on the audiences' acceptability and be acceptable in the oral conventions of the target culture (李昌盛等, 2014; Macro, 2002).

Grammar and vocabulary should be understood by the target spectators (焦菊隱, 2005).

Actability:

Pursuing the suitability between words and actions (李昌盛等, 2014; Marco, 2002; Pavis, 1989)

Reflecting the actions that speakers want to carry out (英若誠, 1999)

Expressing characters' purposes and psychological activities, as well as stimulating both sides involved in the dialogues to promote dramatic conflict (孟偉根, 2012)

Individuality:

Reflecting the personality and image of the characters (英若誠, 1999; 老舍, 1999; Hamberg, 1969)

Corresponding to the identity of characters, the times and environment they live in and their life experiences (孟偉根, 2012)



- Previous Studies on the English Translation of *The Peach Blossom Fan*

Research Contents:

The translation of the cultural elements in the original text (梁雪、丁淑梅, 2022; 李咪, 2019; 尤贊蕾, 2019; 王南穎, 2015)

The beauty of artistic conception, rhyme and form of librettos in Xu's translation (易威伟、谢仪瑄, 2021)

Translator's behavior characteristics (李震, 2022)

- **Previous Studies on the Performability of Drama**

Research Contents:

Assess the speakability or colloquialism of actors' lines (张汨, 2023; 任晓霏等, 2011)

Assess the actability (刘立胜, 2023; 马晴, 2023; 胡明华, 2022)

Analyze the translation methods adopted to make the translations intelligible (黄萌, 2019; 韩江洪、胡蒙楠, 2016; 李广欢, 2014)

Assess the individuality (杨瑞, 2022; 黄勤、刘晓黎, 2015; 聂玉景, 2010)

Focus on the rhythm of librettos to assess performability (刘立胜, 2023; 杨瑞, 2022)

The fluency of dialogues (马晴, 2023); Audience subjectivity (黄萌, 2019); Non-linguistic elements (黄勤、刘晓黎, 2015)



- **Previous Studies on the Subtitle Translation of Drama**

Research Contents:

Emphasize that subtitle translation should follow the principle of being concise and clear (閼艳华, 2024; 李静, 2023; 王群沣, 2018)

Emphasize that subtitle translation should not blindly follow the principle of brevity (Jiadong Zheng and Deyan Zou, 2023; 张玲, 2022; Yilei Yuan and Duoxiu Qian, 2021)

Emphasize that subtitle translation should restore the beauty of rhythm in the original text and convey the emotions of the protagonists (严婷, 2024; 李静, 2023; 覃潇婧, 2019)



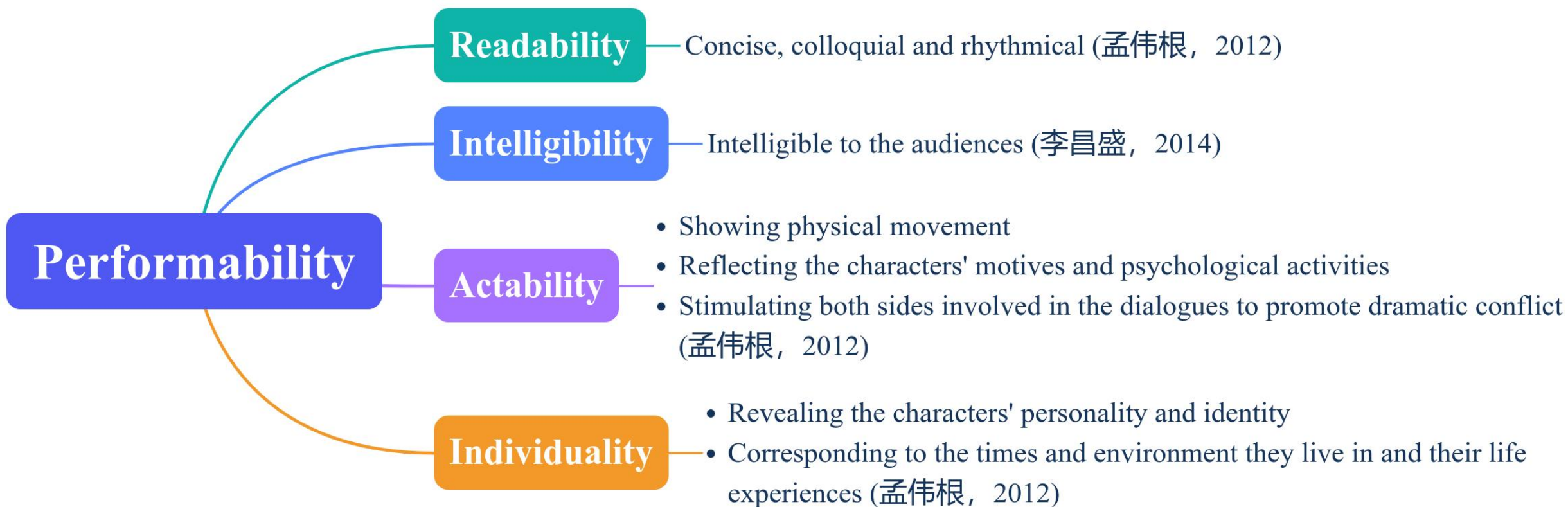
SUMMARY

At present, the study on the performability of the English translation of *1699 Peach Blossom Fan* mainly explores whether the English translation of cultural elements can be understood by foreign audiences, and summarizes the strategies for translating these cultural elements, which mainly relates to assessing the intelligibility. The exploration of speakability, actability and individuality, which is important to assess its performability, is not given attention.

Moreover, as a subtitle translated text, the readability of this translation and its coordination with the performance are still not studied.

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Readability-Length of Subtitles

	Rule for the Length of Subtitles	the Length of English Subtitles for <i>1699 Peach Blossom Fan</i>
Number of Characters	35-42 characters per line	6% contains more than 35-42 characters per line.
Duration of Stay on the Screen	6 seconds	These 6% subtitles stay on the screen basically far more than 6 seconds.

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Readability-Colloquialism and Brevity of the Spoken Parts

- Flesch Reading Ease:

Flesch Reading Ease Score	Flesch-Kincaid Grade Level	Reading Level	Reading Note
77.87	4.64	7 th grade	Fairly easy to read

- Sentence Length:

Rule for the Sentence Length (Butler, 1985)	Average Sentence Length
Short sentences: 1-9 words Medium sentences: 10-25 words Long sentences: 25 words or more	8.7

Readability-Colloquialism and Brevity of the Spoken Parts

- Word Length:

Rule for the Word Length (蔡永贵, 2015)	Average Word Length
Less than 4 letters: relatively simple vocabularies	4.3
More than 4 letters: complex vocabularies	

- Lexical Complexity:

GSL-1 (General Service List-1)	GSL-2	AWL (Academic Word List)	Not in lists
78.72%	4.91%	1.07%	15.3%



Readability-Librettos

ST

齊梁詞賦 陳隋花柳 A
日日芳情迤逗 B
青衫偎倚 今番小杜揚州 B
尋思描黛 指點吹簫 從此春入手 B
秀才渴病急須救 A
偏是斜陽遲下樓 剛飲得一杯酒 A

TT

In the Southern Dynasties, the pleasures of literature
and leisurereached their apogee, A
and scholars cloistered themselves off from the
world with their favourites. A
My beloved's gentle weight on my shoulder brings
to mind that glorious era. B
I paint her ebony eyebrows, and teach her to hold the
flute. Thus do I let the germ of love mature. B
Ah, how I have pined for love. A
Now, the sun disappearsbehind the hills, casting
shadows on my now-empty cup. A



Readability-Librettos

ST	TT
俺曾见金陵玉殿莺啼晓 秦淮水榭花开早 眼看他起朱楼 眼看他宴宾客 眼看他楼塌了	At dawn, I have heard the oriole sing by the great houses of Nanjing. I have seen the flowers blossom by the riverside. I saw them build the courtesan's quarters, saw them feast and make merry. But I saw, too, how the building collapsed.



Intelligibility

	ST	TT
Social Culture-loaded Words	侯方域，表字朝宗 下官杨文聪，表字龙友 下官马士英，别字瑶草	Hou Fangyu Yang Wencong Ma Shiying
Material Culture-loaded Words	翠菱花	the mirrors
Linguistic Culture-loaded Words	豺虎	bandit
Allusions	齐梁词赋 陈隋花柳	In the Southern Dynasties, the pleasures of literature and leisure reached their apogee



Actability

ST	TT
便等他三年，便等他十年，便等他百年， 只不嫁外人。	May it be three years, or ten, or one hundred: <u>it is immaterial.</u> I shall never marry another.



Individuality

ST	TT
那知道这几件钗钏衣裙，原放不到我香君眼里。脱裙衫，穷不妨，布荆人，名自香。	You must understand that hairpins, baubles, or fine raiment holds no charm for one such as I. <u>What does it matter if I must dispense with such trifles?</u> I am willing to live in poverty; for even a pauper may earn honour for her virtue.

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Research Findings

1. The translation basically achieves readability. Using short words, general words, and short sentences, and presenting rhythmic patterns can enhance the readability.
2. In most cases, the translated text is understandable. Using the same translation when translating different names of the same character and free translation help to improve the intelligibility.
3. The translation basically presents the inner activities of characters. Amplification, free translation, and the use of exclamatory sentences and rhetorical questions help to present gestic language.
4. The translation succeeds in presenting the traits and images of characters. The individuality of the lines can also be achieved through amplification and free translation.

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Thank you!

Any advice and correction will be appreciated!

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